WHAT'S INSIDE A MUSTARD SEED?

Every Bitter Thing Is Sweet

Balsamic Thai Chili Brussels Sprouts

Good Charlie's–inspired, with beef bacon and Parmesan

Test batch — we'll update this card as we tweak it.



> "The full soul loathes a honeycomb; but to the hungry soul every bitter thing is sweet."
>
> Mishlei 27:7, The Word of יהוה

Category: Vegetables / Sides

Servings: 4 side servings

Time: About 35–40 minutes (10 minutes prep, about 30 minutes cooking)

You'll need: A large rimmed metal baking sheet (unlined), a skillet, a small saucepan, and a large heat-safe bowl

Clean eating: Beef bacon with no pork ingredients. Choose a sweet chili sauce without shellfish, and a Parmesan-style cheese made with microbial or vegetarian enzymes if rennet source matters to you.

Source: Inspired by the Balsamic Thai Chili Brussels sprouts at Good Charlie's on FM 1488 — our copycat test version, not the restaurant's recipe.

Ingredients

Original batch

Sprouts

- **1 pound** small fresh Brussels sprouts, halved through the stem
- **2 tablespoons** olive oil
  Swap 1 tablespoon for reserved beef bacon fat, if you like.
- **¼ teaspoon** fine salt, plus more to taste
- **¼ teaspoon** black pepper

Beef bacon

- **4 ounces** beef bacon, cut into ½-inch pieces

Balsamic Thai chili glaze

- **3 tablespoons** Thai sweet chili sauce, not plain chili paste
- **2 tablespoons** balsamic vinegar
- **1 tablespoon** balsamic glaze
- **¼ teaspoon** garlic powder

To finish

- **¼ cup** finely grated Parmesan, plus a little more for serving

Steps

Before you start

1. Set a rack in the middle of the oven and heat it to **450°F**.
2. Rinse the sprouts and dry them thoroughly — dry sprouts brown, wet ones steam. Trim the dry stem ends without cutting so far that the leaves fall away.
3. Halve the sprouts through the stem. Quarter any unusually large ones so the pieces match in size.

Cook the beef bacon

4. Drain any liquid from the package and pat the bacon dry (do not rinse). Put the pieces in a cold skillet and set the burner to medium.
5. Cook, stirring often, until cooked through with crisp edges, following the package directions. Move to a paper-towel-lined plate.
6. Reserve 1 tablespoon of the rendered fat if you'd like to use it in place of some of the olive oil.

Roast the sprouts

7. Toss the sprouts with the olive oil (or oil plus reserved bacon fat), salt, and pepper until thinly, evenly coated.
8. Arrange them **cut-side down** on the unlined sheet with space between pieces. Use two pans if they're crowded.
9. Roast 15 minutes, then check the undersides with a spatula. Small sprouts may be ready at 12 minutes.

> Time-sensitive: you want deep golden-brown cut faces and centers a fork slides into with slight resistance.

10. If needed, roast 3–8 minutes more until deeply browned. Use oven mitts with the hot pan.

Glaze and finish

11. While the sprouts roast, whisk the sweet chili sauce, balsamic vinegar, balsamic glaze, garlic powder, and pepper flakes (if using) in a small saucepan.
12. Warm over **medium-low**, stirring, until steaming and lightly coating a spoon. Don't let it boil hard — the sugars scorch fast.
13. Move the hot sprouts to a large heat-safe bowl. Toss with half the glaze, then add more a spoonful at a time until glossy but not puddled. You may not need it all.
14. Fold in the crisp beef bacon, transfer to a serving dish, shower with Parmesan, and serve right away.

Nutrition estimate

Nutrition Facts *estimate*

1 of 4 side servings

Calories	250
	% Daily Value*
Total Fat 14g	**18%**
Saturated Fat 4g	**20%**
Sodium 695mg	**30%**
Total Carbohydrate 22g	**8%**
Dietary Fiber 4g	**16%**
Total Sugars 12g	
Protein 10g	**21%**

*Percent Daily Values are based on a 2,000-calorie diet.



- Fat **49%** of calories
- Carbs **34%** of calories
- Protein **16%** of calories

Estimates per serving, calculated from USDA FoodData Central reference values and typical beef bacon, sweet chili sauce, and Parmesan labels. Assumes all of the glaze is used; brands and how much glaze you add will change the numbers.

Kitchen notes

- Small sprouts are what we remember from Good Charlie's — use them when you can.
- Tasting the first batch: was theirs sweeter, tangier, or hotter? Adjust the sweet chili, vinegar, or pepper flakes next time and note it here.
- For the bacon-free plate we actually ordered, turn off the beef bacon above and use the full 2 tablespoons of olive oil.